MEMORY DRIFT

WHAT WAS I AGAIN?

Interactive installation

Game, image and spatial experience

ABOUT THE PROJECT

Memory Drift explores the gap between a stored image and a changing recollection. Visitors study one photograph, collect its fragments, and answer the same question three times: were there three, four or five people? The ending compares the original, the system's reconstructions and their answers.

INSPIRATION

When memory differs from the record

The act of remembering changes the memory itself.

The Mandela effect reveals a gap between what we vividly remember and what was recorded. That moment of doubt became the starting point for this project.

COLLECTIVE MEMORY

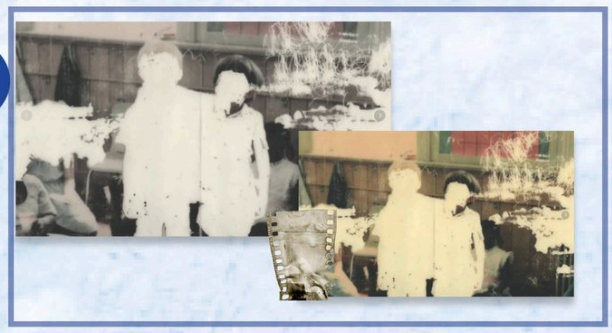
REPEATED RECALL



The Mandela effect begins with a familiar image that feels unmistakably right, until it is compared with the original. I was drawn to that moment of doubt: if many people remember the same detail differently, what makes a memory feel true?

MEMORY DISTORTION

FALSE CERTAINTY



THE SAME PHOTO, LOOKED AT AGAIN

Repeated Recall



BACKGROUND

Memory in the digital age

Photos, messages and cloud archives preserve traces of everyday life. This project asks whether keeping these records also preserves how an experience is remembered.

External Memory

Photos, cloud albums, messages and social media have become external systems for storing personal memories.

WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS

19 / 22

answered four people the first time. That is the number in the photo.

By the third time, 5 of 22 had moved away from four: 3 said five and 2 were not sure.

5 of 21 took the piece the road pair offered.

Memory ≠ Data

Data can remain unchanged while human memory continues to be reconstructed through every act of recall.



STORED, NOT REVISITED

≈70%

of photographs are never viewed again.

Does storing an image keep its memory alive?

PUBLIC SURVEY ANALYSIS

We save photographs to hold on to memories, yet many are rarely revisited. Some images are deliberately avoided, revealing a tension between preservation and forgetting.

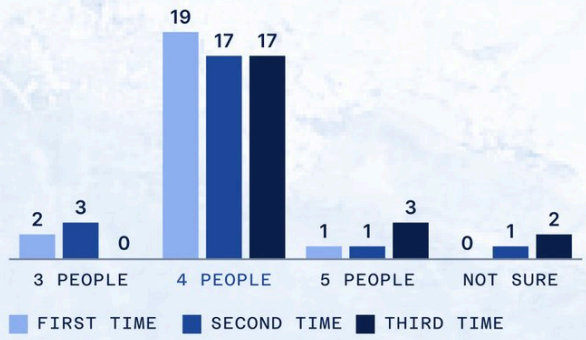
KEEP **REVISIT** **STEP AWAY**

DESIGN IMPLICATION

I don't want the game to tell people they should remember everything. Keeping, looking back and letting go are all fine choices. In the game, collecting pieces is keeping, answering the same question again is looking back, and losing pieces is letting go.



ANSWERS TO "HOW MANY PEOPLE?"



22 plays recorded by the web version, 23–24 Oct 2026.
The photo had four people.

THE BURDEN OF KEEPING

≈50%

Around half reported stress linked to a disorganised photo library.



5 IN 10 RESPONDENTS

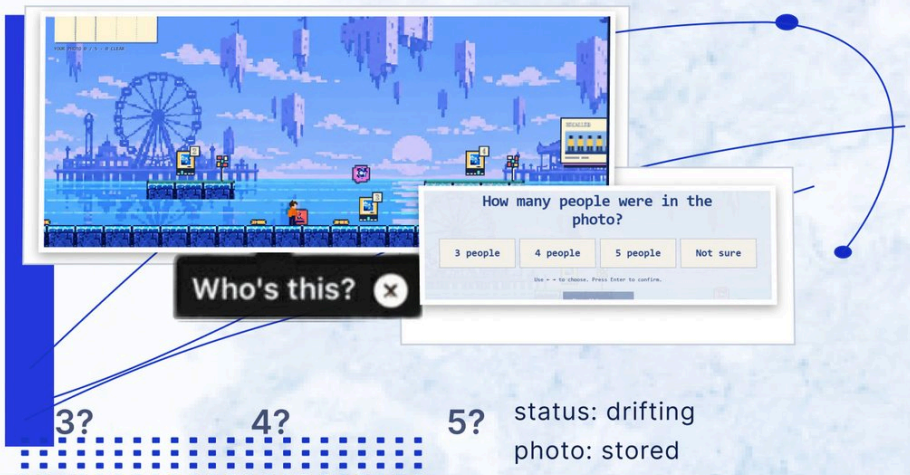
Keeping can become work. Choosing not to revisit may also be meaningful.

DESIGN CONCEPT

MEMORY DRIFT · INTERACTIVE INSTALLATION

— WHY A GAME?

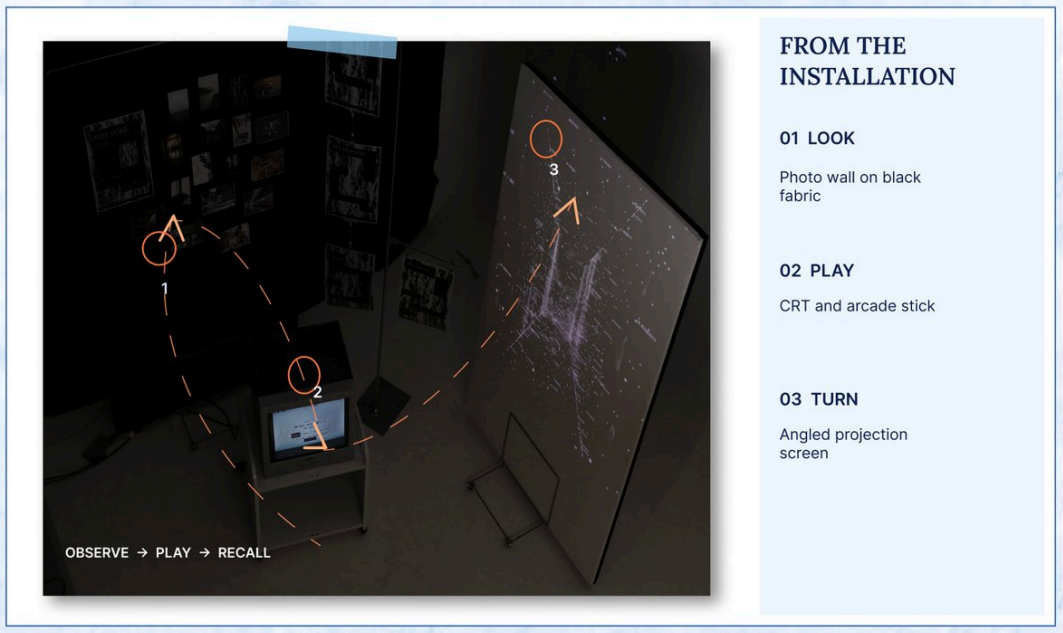
Visitors study one photograph, answer whether it shows three, four or five people, then collect image fragments. The question returns three times before the final comparison.



— THE INTERACTION

The ending compares the original image, the system's reconstructions and the visitor's three answers.

One photograph. Three recalls. A final comparison.



FROM THE INSTALLATION

01 LOOK

Photo wall on black fabric

02 PLAY

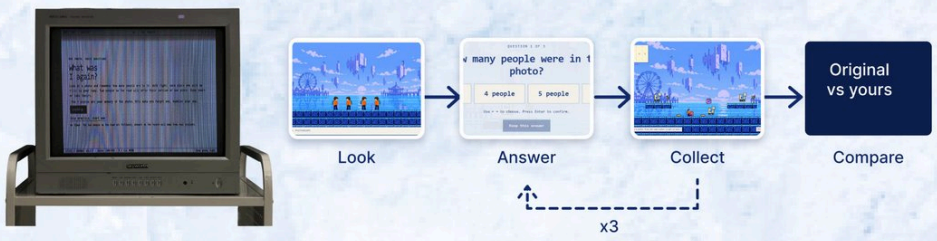
CRT and arcade stick

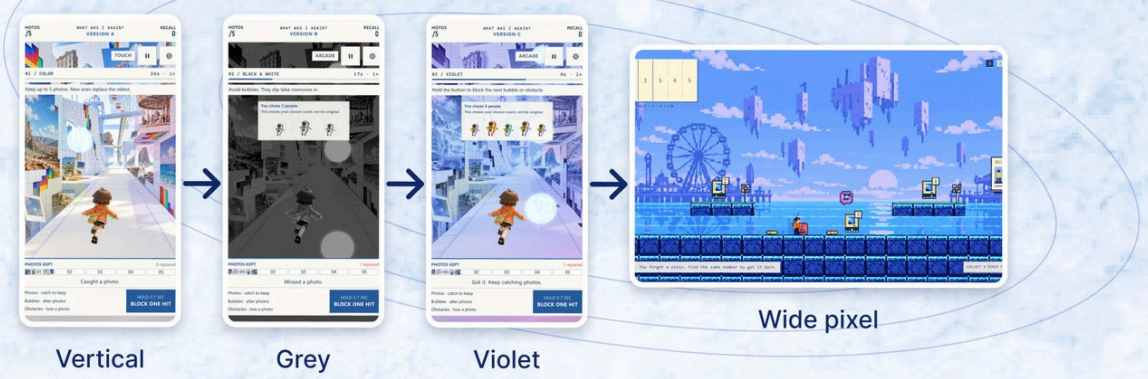
03 TURN

Angled projection screen

Side-scrolling movement lets visitors collect photo fragments between recall questions.

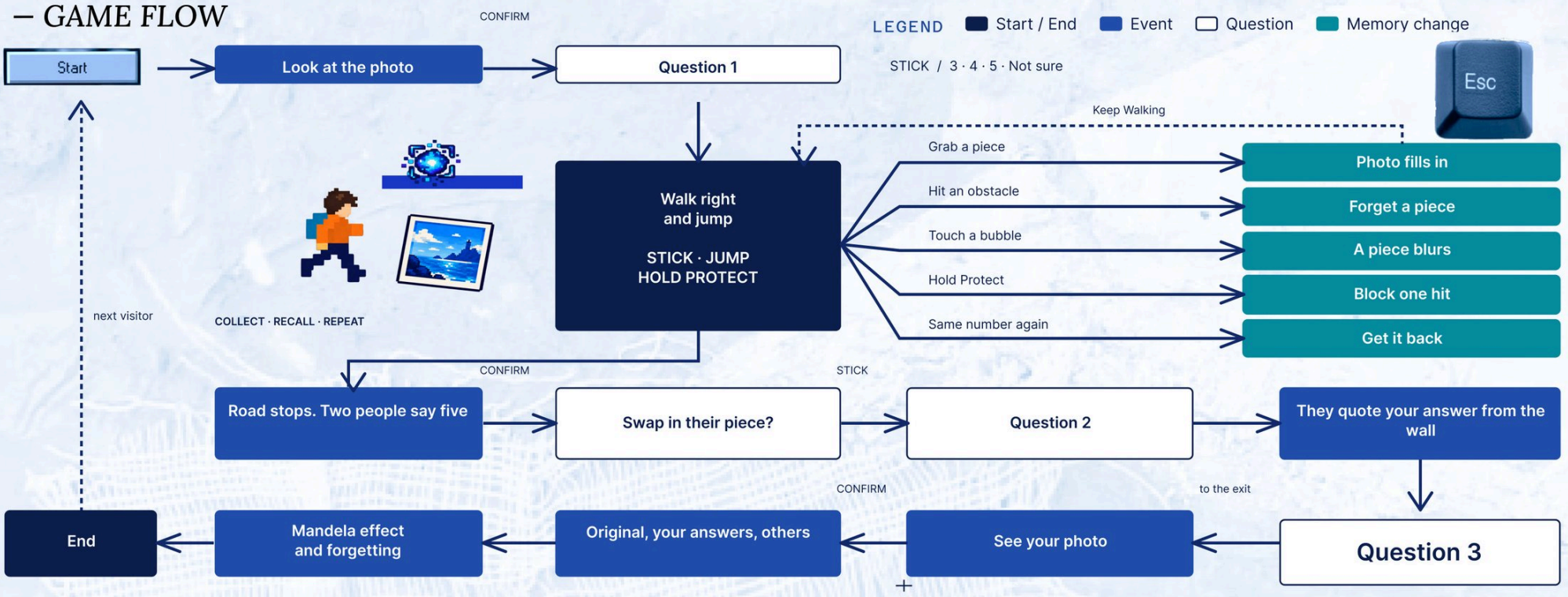
— CORE GAMEPLAY DESIGN





Visual tests moved toward enlarged pixel forms for the CRT. The final interaction centres on collecting fragments and repeated recall.

— GAME FLOW



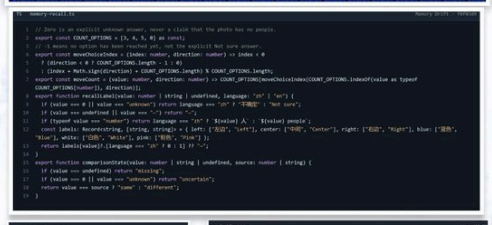
— GAME

The game was developed and tested on screen, then adapted for the CRT. The compact pixel resolution keeps its forms legible. Controller and installation tests informed later adjustments.

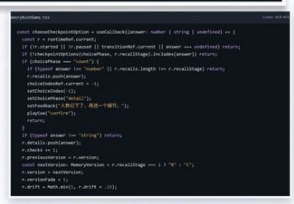


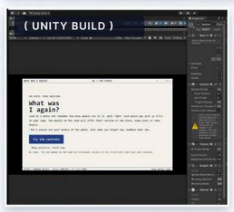














— CONTROLLER

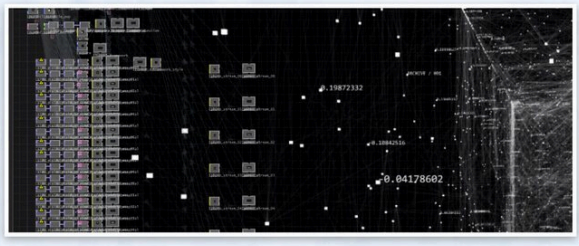
A joystick and buttons give visitors a direct way to move, collect fragments and confirm each answer.



```
// app/pixel-input.ts  ·  press a button to reassign it
if (capturedAction && newlyPressed.length) {
  const index = newlyPressed[0];
  const other = ACTIONS.find(a => a !== action && bindings[a] === index);
  bindings = { ...bindings, [action]: index };
  if (other) bindings[other] = oldIndex;   // swap, never lose a button
  savePixelBindings(bindings);
}
```

— TOUCHDESIGNER

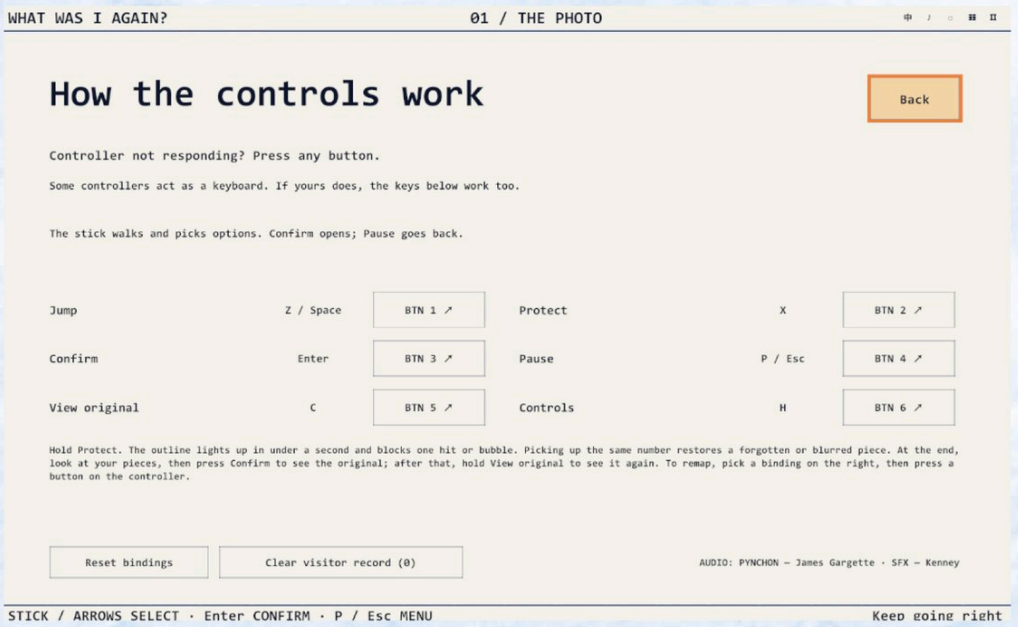
I made a tunnel out of points and lines in TouchDesigner, with my photos floating along the sides. The photos slowly fade, but the numbers stay. That's the whole project in one picture: the data stays, the memory doesn't.



GAME OUTPUT

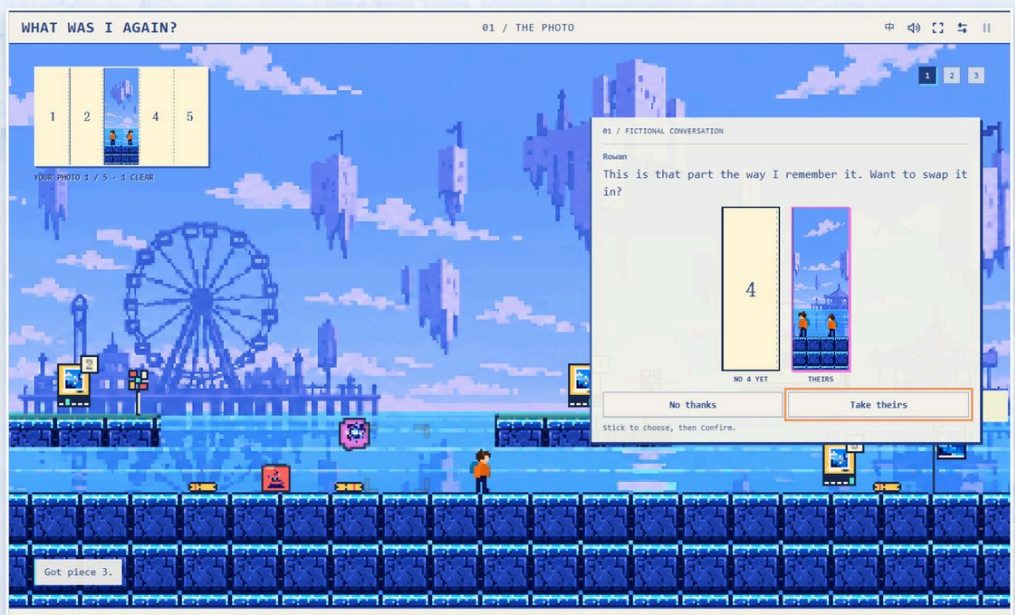
ONE IMAGE · THREE RECALLS · A CHANGING RECORD













MORE FROM THE GAME / A TALK ON THE ROAD / TAKE A LOOK / COLLECT











WHAT THE GAME OUTPUT SHOWS

The photograph never changes. The player's version of it does.

THE PHOTO

Five pieces stand for your memory of the photograph.

THE GAME

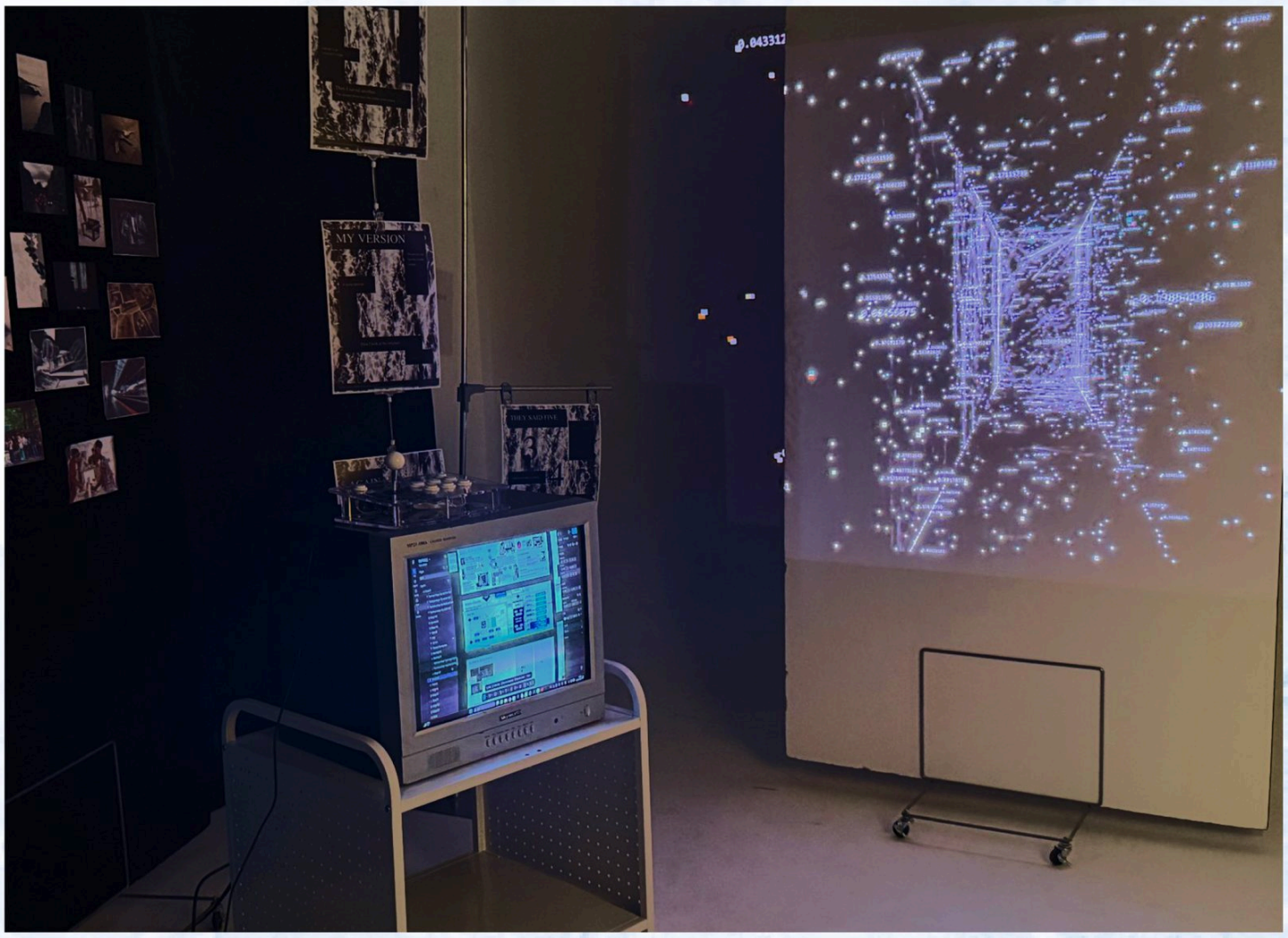
Hits make you forget a piece. Bubbles blur one.

THE RECORD

The wall quotes answers from real visitors.

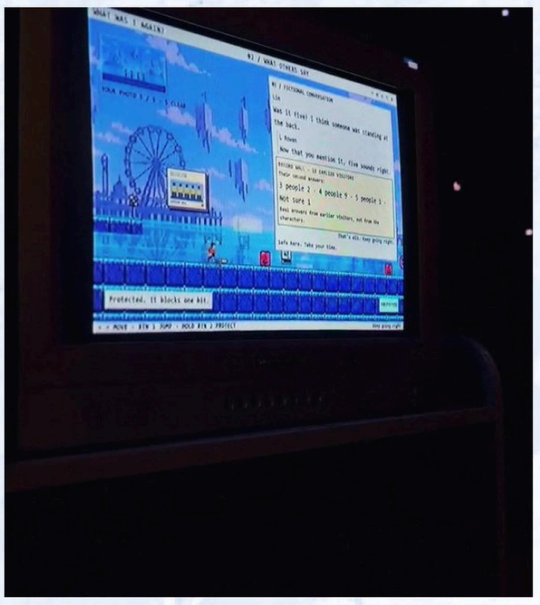
INSTALLATION

PHOTO WALL · CRT AND ARCADE STICK · ANGLED PROJECTION



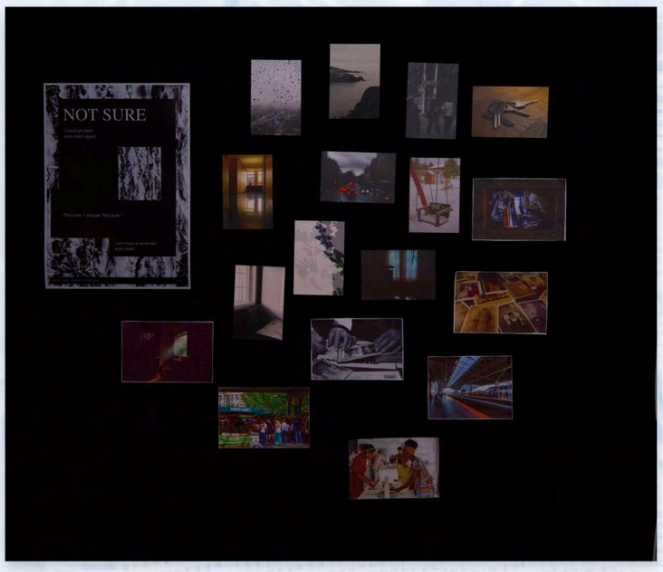




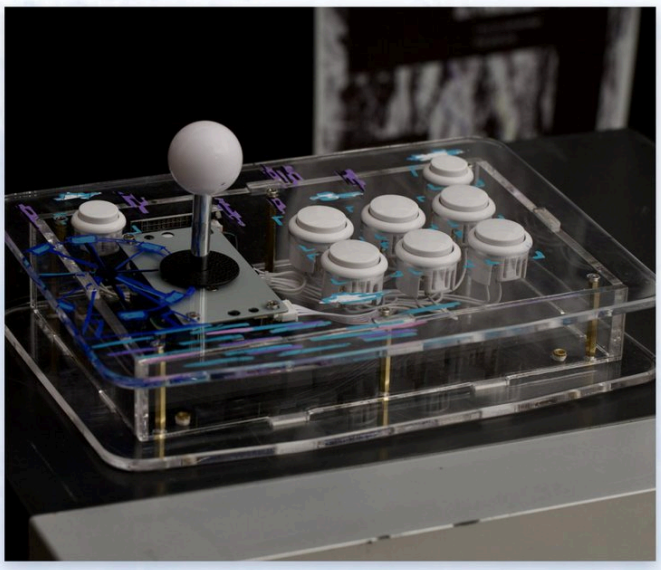




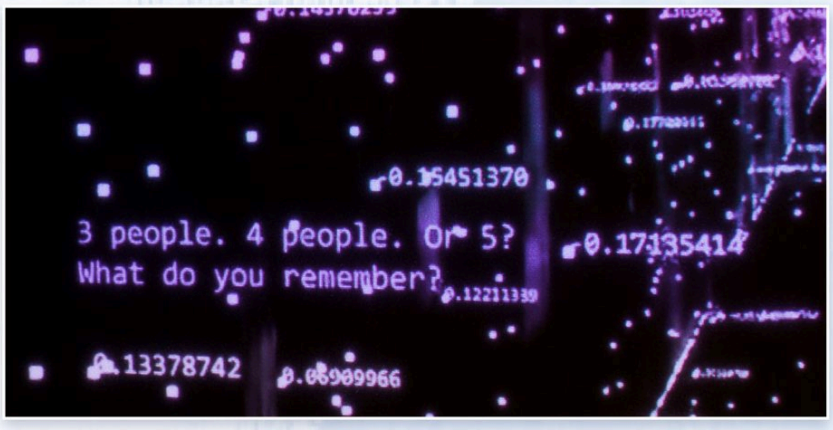








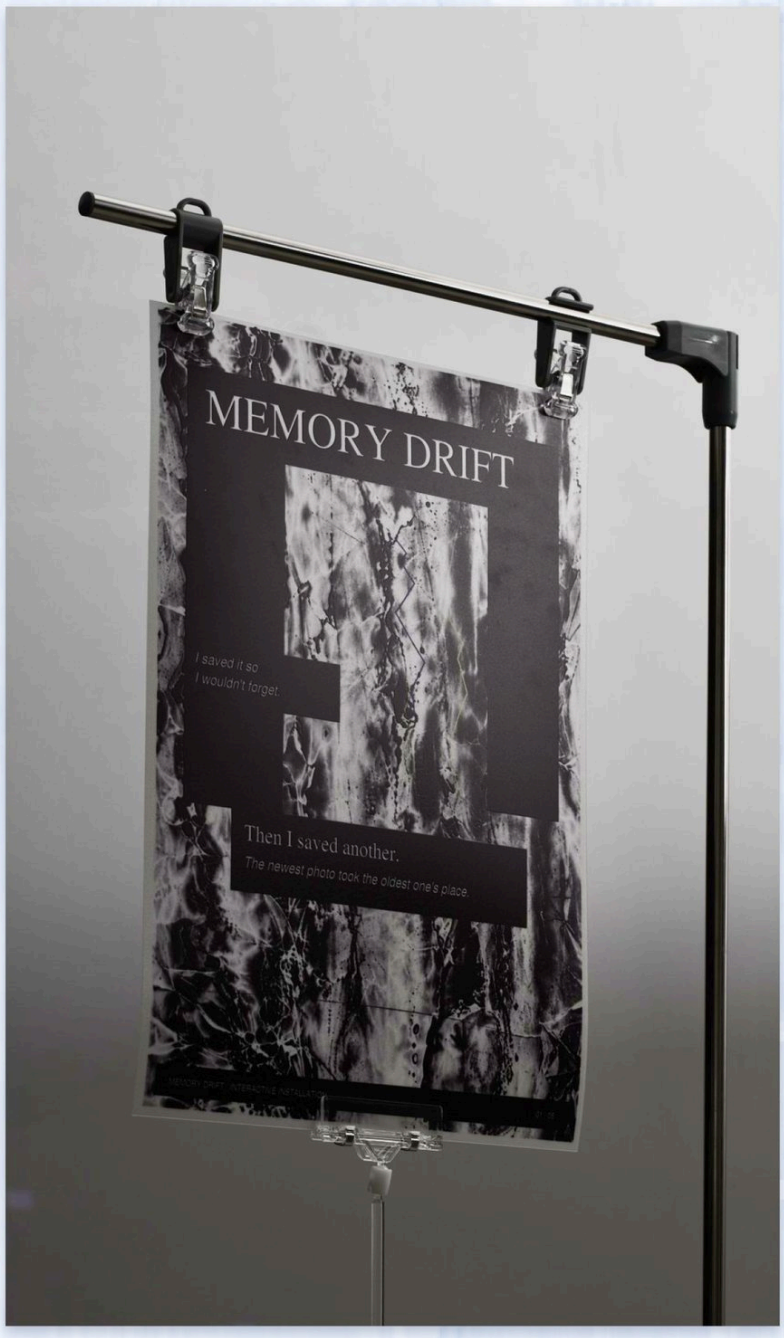




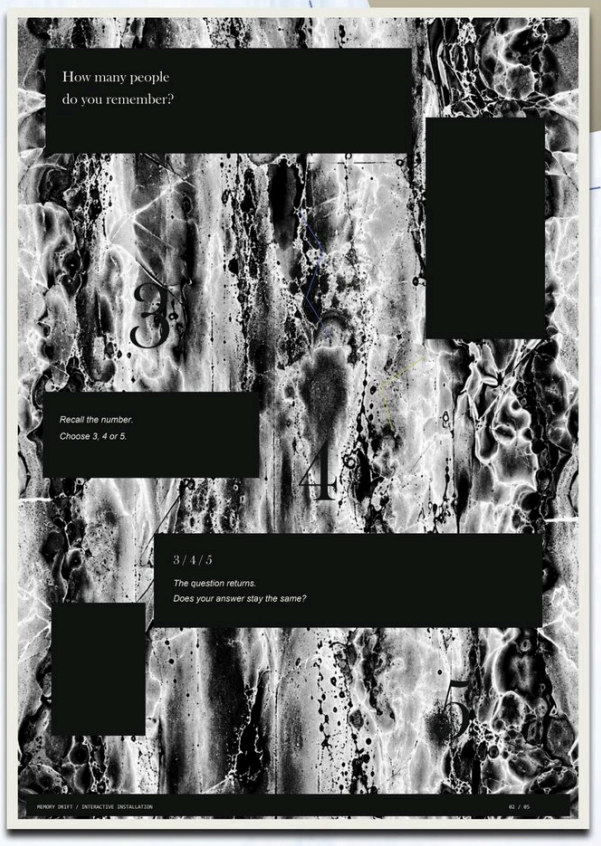


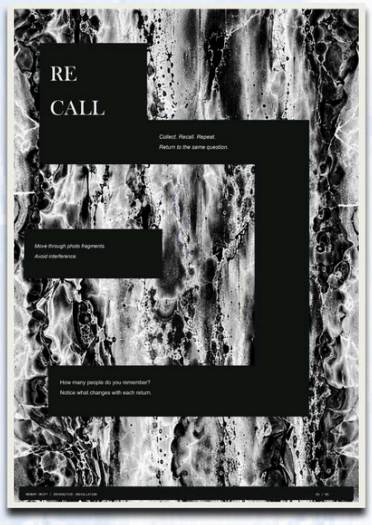
POSTER DESIGN

FIVE POSTERS · ONE PHOTOGRAPH · THREE ROUNDS OF RECALL

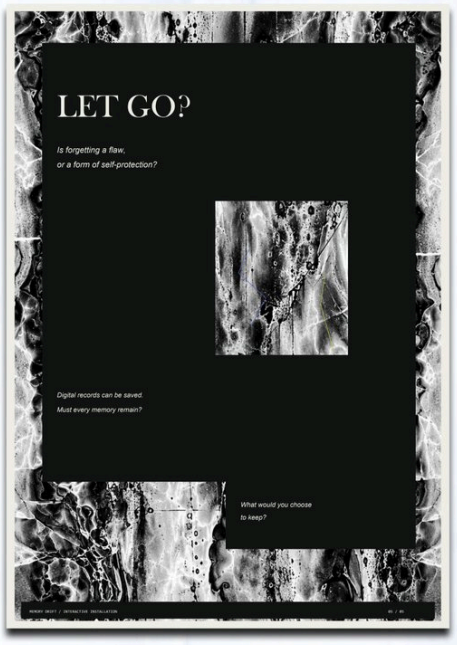










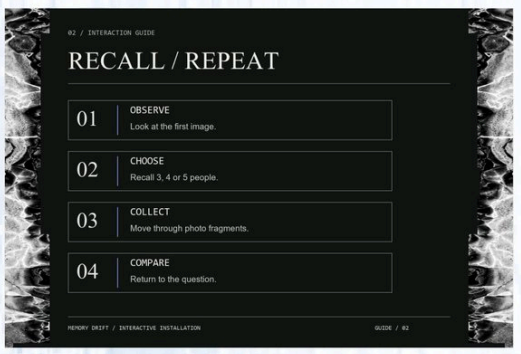


THE FIXED RECORD

A photograph can remain unchanged, yet the way we remember it can shift. This poster series begins with that gap between the recorded image and the version held in memory.







VISUAL LANGUAGE

Repeated images, broken textures and displaced text make each poster feel like a record that has been revisited. The black and white palette echoes the installation's printed photographs while allowing small changes to become visible.

FIVE VERSIONS, ONE QUESTION

Across the series, fragments reappear in different positions. Like the game's three rounds of recall, each return invites the viewer to look again and question what they thought they had seen.

WHY THIS PALETTE

The posters use only black, white and grey. A black-and-white negative has no colour to rely on, so what you remember is the shape and the gap. The game does the opposite: blue and bright pixels stay in the screen, while the posters keep the colourless, printed record. The one image changes only in its fragments, the way a memory loses its detail but keeps its outline.

THE FIVE POSTERS

WHAT REMAINS?
HOW MANY PEOPLE?
RECALL
A DIFFERENT VERSION
LET GO?

